Chapter Ninety-Three

The Loss of France

Between 1422 and 1453,
Jeanne d'Arc helps the king of France
regain his throne and dies for it,
the French are victorious in the
Hundred Years' War,
and both rival kings lose their wits

HENRY V HAD TAKEN FRANCE; but except for the city of Paris and the lands immediately around it, his claim was a paper one. He had the support of the Duke of Burgundy; but the anti-Burgundian party, the Armagnacs, had allied themselves behind the young disinherited Dauphin. Charles VII had handed over the Dauphin's right to inherit; but the old king was still alive, and Henry V spent the years after the Battle of Agincourt fighting against the Dauphin's supporters. By 1422, says Walsingham's *Chronica*, "a great part" of his army, "weakened through fighting and lack of food . . . went back to England, with very little intention of returning to France again."[1]

Henry remained, but all of his adult life had been spent at war, and the dysentery that stalked every army had become chronic in him. He died suddenly on August 30, 1422, just short of ten years on the throne, just four miles away from Paris.

Back in England, his nine-month-old son was proclaimed Henry VI, "king